Emotional Reactions to Script Variations: A Multigenerational Study in Visual Typography Design

Maahi R Solanki, Ananthula Thanvi, Pranitha Srikruthi, Pratha Chauhan, Anushka Saraf, Madhuri Solegaonkar, Arunita Paul

Introduction

Typography and script choice have cultural and emotional significance that goes beyond simple legibility. Designers and researchers understand that typefaces possess unique "personas" and can express mood, attitude, or tone. Research shows that well-selected typography can improve readers' mood and thinking. Most studies, however, focus on font styles—like serif versus sans-serif—or general user experience. They often overlook script variation, such as using Latin versus non-Latin scripts, and how different age groups interpret these variations emotionally in multilingual contexts. In our globalized world, mismatches between script design and audience expectations can create confusion or disengagement. This study aims to fill this gap by exploring the emotional impact of script variations on users from various age groups in multilingual design.

Methodology

The method of data collection was done using a quantitative survey study with three age groups: 18–25 years (youth), 26–45 years (middle-aged), and 46+ years (older adults). We gathered 47 responses. The materials used were typographic posters conveying abstract or metaphorical messages through expressive lettering. Each poster featured a specific script (for instance, Tamil or Bengali script, or an unfamiliar script) without any explanatory text; the goal was to rely solely on visual form. After viewing each poster, participants answered a multiple-choice question with four interpretation options reflecting different emotional or thematic responses, like "lost in thought" or "quiet isolation." There was no "correct" answer expected; we aimed to measure which emotional interpretation each participant associated with the design.

Results

The data show a definite age-related difference in emotional interpretation. Overall, younger adults (18–25) showed the highest emotional engagement, often selecting introspective or symbolic interpretations. For one poster, a large percentage of 18–25 participants picked responses like "Lost in thought" or "Symbolic meaning," while very few older adults did. Many older participants chose "Clean but no emotion." When we asked how thought-provoking the posters were, a majority of young adults considered them "thought-provoking" or "visually interesting," while

older adults often found them “hard to relate to.” Middle-aged adults (26–45) fell somewhere in between; they appreciated the design's aesthetics but had mixed emotional reactions. In one question about emotions communicated, many 26–45 participants chose neutral options like “Mysterious” (moderate) or “Distant,” indicating some engagement without strong emotional involvement. In contrast, older adults (46+) frequently reported emotional detachment. They described the posters as “sterile,” “minimal & distant,” or simply noted the language/script. In the survey summary question, a significant portion of the 46+ group marked the posters as “hard to relate” and highlighted differences in script as a notable factor. These response patterns suggest younger viewers readily impose metaphorical narratives on abstract designs, while older viewers prioritize clarity and context. This aligns with research indicating that visual taste stabilizes in early to mid-adulthood, with both younger and older individuals sometimes displaying more variable interpretations. In our study, younger viewers offered the most creative interpretations, while the oldest group focused on literal readability.

Discussion

1. Generational Emotional Perception Gap: The survey shows a gap in how different generations interpret design. Participants aged 18 to 25 often used emotional phrases like “calm outside, emotions inside,” “metaphorical story,” and “lost in thought.” This suggests they view abstract typography as layered and meaningful. In contrast, participants aged 46 and older described designs with more technical or neutral terms such as “minimal and distant,” “neat but no emotion,” and “language/script.” This indicates they see designs at a surface level. Younger viewers are more open to finding hidden meanings in unclear visuals, while older adults prefer direct and familiar cues. These findings suggest that younger generations look for fresh ideas in design, while older generations stick to established norms like clear, high-contrast typefaces.

2. Symbolism vs. Minimalism: Younger participants (18 to 25) were more likely to see symbolism in the posters. They often interpreted design elements as metaphorical, referring to a “story beneath the surface.” Older adults, however, viewed the same minimal features as lacking content, perceiving them as empty rather than intentionally vague. What younger viewers understood as powerful symbolism seemed like unemotional minimalism to older viewers. This aligns with broader communication design research: designers might assume abstract visuals hold meaning, but some audiences may see them as incomplete. This suggests that very stylized or symbolic type can alienate older users unless it's paired with clear narratives or familiar icons.

3. Design Appeal vs. Emotional Engagement: Across all age groups, basic design elements like composition, contrast, and color captured attention. However, this did not always lead to emotional engagement, especially among older viewers. While many participants found the layouts visually appealing, older respondents often settled for saying they “look nice” without feeling any deeper connection. One participant noted that a strong font pairing caught their eye, but without clear context, it felt “empty.” This shows that good design can attract a wide audience, but its interpretation largely depends on the viewer’s background and expectations.

4. Language and Interpretation Styles: A clear difference appeared in the language used to describe the posters. Younger adults opted for emotional and experiential phrases like “lost in thought,” “emotionally stuck,” and “quiet isolation.” They treated the design as a personal experience. Older adults, on the other hand, used factual terms like “clean but no emotion,” “language/script,” and “minimal and distant,” regarding the posters more as objects. Middle-aged respondents used a mix of both styles. This suggests that messaging strategies might need to adjust—emotional, immersive language for younger audiences and straightforward, explanatory text for older ones.

5. Cultural and Experiential Disconnect: The repeated feedback of “hard to relate” from the 46 and older group highlights a cultural or experiential gap. Even with effective design, older participants often felt the content did not connect with their lives. Middle-aged participants varied more, sometimes relating based on their familiarity with the concept. This emphasizes the importance of cultural relevance: when visual themes or underlying ideas are unfamiliar, older viewers may disengage, no matter how appealing the design is.

Conclusion and Recommendations

This study highlights a clear generational divide in the emotional interpretation of typographic designs in different scripts. Younger viewers project narratives and emotions onto abstract letterforms, while older viewers focus on readability and concrete meaning. To design inclusively for multi-age, multilingual audiences, we propose the following recommendations:

• **Multi-script integration**: Present scripts together (e.g., side-by-side or overlapped) to create a unified design element. This allows users to see multiple scripts as part of a cohesive message, leveraging older viewers’ familiarity while still allowing for creative interplay with younger viewers.

• **Typographic emotion mapping**: Even if a script is unfamiliar to some viewers, modify the letterforms’ anatomy to convey emotion. For instance, use looser letter spacing or curved stroke endings to suggest calmness, or condensed bold forms for urgency. Such visual cues (spacing, contrast, rhythm) can influence emotional perception.

• **Consistent color-emotion coding**: Use color intentionally across scripts so that emotional tone transcends language. For example, consistently apply warm hues (reds and oranges) for energetic or passionate messages and cool hues (blues and greens) for calm or peaceful themes. This way, even if the script isn’t read, the color's mood communicates across cultures and ages.

• **Accessibility and clarity**: Ensure at least one script (often the local or dominant script) is presented in a highly legible style for older readers. Use larger point sizes, high contrast, and avoid overly decorative type for that "clarity layer." For example, a clear sans-serif font could present the main message alongside a secondary decorative script. This complies with guidelines that suggest older adults prefer larger, simpler typefaces for readability.

• **Tactile and visual texture**: Integrate subtle textures or layering in typography to create depth. For younger audiences, a textured or layered effect can imply complexity and intrigue. At the same time, ensure the overall image remains visually clear so that older viewers can still perceive a rich design, even if they don't interpret its symbolism.

• **Embedded iconography**: Where possible, incorporate recognizable shapes or icons into the letterforms (e.g., cultural symbols, common objects). This approach makes an abstract script more concrete. For instance, a stroke in one character could subtly resemble a familiar symbol. Such cues can help older viewers grasp meaning without detracting from the creative design.

• **Interpretive storytelling in form**: Allow the typography itself to tell a story (e.g., flowing letters to suggest movement, splitting letters for dual concepts), but anchor it with at least one clear point of reference (like a common typeface word or a pictogram). This way, abstract designs hint at a narrative, offering novelty for youth and context for seniors.

By applying these strategies, designers can create multilingual typographic work that captures attention across ages through strong design, color, and composition, while also resonating emotionally with each group. Ensuring readability and cultural cues satisfies older audiences' need for clarity, while layered symbolism and aesthetic flair engage younger viewers. In summary, balancing emotional depth with visual clarity is essential for inclusive typographic design.

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Keywords

Typography, script variations, emotional design, generational differences, multilingual communication